

TORTURED LOVE
A still from *Saiyaara*, directed by Mohit Suri



> **"YRF AND MOHIT SURI'S *SAIYAARA* IS TURNING OUT TO BE ADITYA CHOPRA AND YRF'S MODERN-DAY *DDLJ*!"**
>
> **KOMAL NAHATA,** *Trade Analyst, on X*

which not only complements his emotional narratives but at times also supercedes it. *Saiyaara*'s album features fresh vocal talent like Faheem Abdullah, who has sung and co-composed the title track, which has busted the charts and has the youth singing along.

Says Suri, "If I have had a good musical record, it's because my education has been with a company that prioritised and paid attention to music and lyrics." He credits his uncles Mahesh and Mukesh Bhatt, whose banner Vishesh Films gave him his big break, and adds, "Music and romance go hand in hand. Tell me one love story that did well but didn't have good music. I like to have my ears to the ground, to stay in touch with what people are hearing and connecting to." Earworms he's anchored like 'Phir Mohabbat', 'Tum Hi Ho' and 'Galliyan' still dominating the airwaves are proof that he knows what he's doing.

MUSIC MEETS FILM

Just a track record of successful romantic releases, however, didn't mean that Suri had an easy time selling the movie to producers. He conceived the film at a time when the genre was struggling to put bums on seats. The industry belief has been that ever since COVID-19, the audience has been content watching love stories from the comfort of their homes on OTT platforms and it is the adrenaline-heavy, larger-than-life action spectacles that are thriving on the big screen.

Suri felt the void. It helped that he had just happened to see *The Romantics*, the Netflix documentary series tracking the origin and rise of Yash Raj Films (YRF). "I was roaming around with the script and a lot of people were genuinely concerned about me and said that no one is going to make a film like this," he says. Loosely inspired by Korean film *A Moment to Remember*, Suri wanted to craft a musical romance around a creative partnership—a hotheaded singer and a heartbroken writer who inspires him and he her.

"[The male lead, played by Panday] has bare raw talent who doesn't know what to do with it; [the female lead, Padda] has the words and knows how to channelise the best from him. They are soul mates but can't be together," he adds. This dynamic is different from the one in his other blockbuster romance, *Aashiqui 2*, which was more supportive than competitive.

Little did Suri know that Yash Raj Films, otherwise busy building up their Spy Universe, was on the lookout for a love story. To invest Rs 50 crore on